

BY ALF VAN HOOSE, assistant sports editor

CLEARWATER, Fla., March 17—There might have been something prophetic in the dark, blustery, chilly clouds that bivouacked above sun-happy Clearwater, Fla., the Ides of March morning.

This was unusual, even for 1960, for, except for a brisk dawn or two, Clearwater and South Florida had spent the month smirking over headlines from the north about snow and rain and sleet.

There's something perversely comforting about bad weather that neighbors have, and Floridians have made the gossip most of it.

But March 15 came up dreary, and it was showery, and a Texas-type gale whistled through the royal palms which guard this community's paths and boulevards. At noon, the weather hadn't done a great deal of moderating, and the temperature was still much lower than the Chamber of Commerce would readily confess.

It was to be the day of a Philadelphia Philly-Washington Senator baseball exhibition in neat little Jack Russell Stadium—a match newsworthy in a backyard sense.

THOUGH NEITHER club, this early in ticket sales or promotions, could afford to present its fullest potential of futility, the game could have, nevertheless, served a purpose.

It could have furnished an early gauge on the worst team in the majors.

"There's a Divinity that shapes men's ends," Hamlet's buddy Horgio once pointed out, so, something took a whack at this contest.

AT 12:21 P.M., the sun still prodigal, the clouds still glowering, and the wind still dancing the Mambo, or something with the palm fronds, the game was cancelled.

At 12:23 p.m., the sun peeped out, the winds quieted somewhat, and the mercury began to sputter.

The Senators, who had come over from Orlando by bus, had jumped aboard by this time—as if fearful of the issue—and the Phils had to troop out to work like countryboys toward school on a May fishing day.

10th of a series

The key day now becomes March 30, at Orlando. The Phils are scheduled to return the Senator visit that afternoon.

UNTIL THEN, however, both clubs will continue to run around in highest society, posing as major leaguers.

Before April 1, the Phils have dates with such people as the Yankees, White Sox, Dodgers and Tigers. They ought to call them off.

It was 10 brief seasons ago, during another fine Clearwater Spring, that Philadelphia built itself a championship team. These were the Whiz Kids, Robin Roberts was here, and Granny Hamner, Curt Simmons, Del Ennis, Bubber Church, Puddinghead Jones and others.

Roberts is here in 1960, though an over-the-hill 33 now, and forms a final rear-guard with Curt Simmons, only 30 but with a left arm that probably has had it. The rest have long since departed.

The manager is the same, too, gentlemanly, scholarly Eddie Sawyer, though he's been fired and re-hired during the decade. Sawyer, too intelligent to predict a pennant in time-honored baseball custom, now falls nicely behind the oldest of football promises.

"We're rebuilding," he says.

A persistent fellow might go from there and detail Sawyer's hopes, but, why bother? Tampa U's football team, under the whip of Coach Marcelino Hoerta, is rebuilding its football team too, but it isn't going to beat Paul Bryant and Alabama next November. Philadelphia isn't going to win the National League pennant either.

SAWYER'S rebuilding includes one pleasant note, however. There is a new coach at first base, Andy Cohen.

"It took me 30 years to get back," says the fellow oldtimers will remember as a Crimson Tide football, basketball and baseball performer of the Roaring 20s, "but I made it."

Cohen left Alabama right after Johnny Mack Brown, Bruce Jones, Wu Winslett, Pooley Hubert and Co., won the greatest Rose Bowl of them all, and soon second-based himself to John McGraw's New York Giants.

IT WAS THE good life, major league baseball, Cohen remembered, but in 1930 it was back to the bushes.

"I kept hoping I'd get back," he went on, "in some way or another, but the chance never came."

There were stops, of varying length, Cohen recalled, at Newark, Minneapolis, Elmire, Pine Bluff, Dayton, Eau Claire, New Orleans, Indianapolis and Denver.

"IT DIDN'T look like I'd ever get another chance, so after 1938 I went back home (El Paso) and decided to give it up.

"Last year I worked as a public relations man. I like the job but last winter John Quinn (Phil GM) called me and offered me a job as a coach with Eddie Sawyer. I unretired right off."

COHEN IS AS active as a teen-ager these days and has that old Philly spirit to the gills.

"Eddie threw every position open this Spring," Cohen said. "We've got some good scraps going on for them."

"It's a challenge, working with this team, and these kids. I love it."

A little later, disillusionment is bound to come to Cohen but this would seem nothing fresh to a man who waited 30 years for an ambition to re-flower.

That life is stern, life is earnest, Cohen learned long ago. He played under Wade, and McGraw, didn't he?

The question became obvious.

"Which one was toughest," he answered. "A-h-a! That's a toughie. It's close, but I'd say McGraw, all round."

McGraw tougher than Wade?

It could be, but there are a number of Alabamians who might argue.